

DRIVING BUSINESS WITH IP: SENTIMENTS FROM SINGAPORE BUSINESS LEADERS

This compendium brings together insights from a series of interviews conducted by the Intellectual Property Office of Singapore (IPOS) and the Singapore Business Federation (SBF). It offers practical advice and real-world strategies on protecting intellectual property (IP) and managing intangible assets (IA), covering key areas like collaboration, commercialisation, and international expansion.

Presented by



In Partnership with



Introduction

In today's turbulent environment defined by supply chain disruptions, geopolitical uncertainties, and soaring costs, businesses face unprecedented challenges. The rise of the knowledge-based economy, the urgent need for digital transformation, and intensifying global competition have made IA and IP more critical than ever.

Recognising this, IPOS and SBF have been collaborating since 2017 to empower Singapore-based businesses to use IP strategically for growth, including international expansion. This partnership was strengthened in 2023 through a Memorandum of Understanding, expanding efforts to support companies in maximising their IP for business success.

To capture business perspectives on IA/IP, IPOS and SBF conducted in-depth interviews with companies navigating these challenges. Their insights and strategies have been distilled into this compendium, offering practical guidance for businesses looking to manage and capitalise on their IA/IP in an increasingly complex and dynamic world.



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We hope to deepen our collaboration with SBF and continue to generate meaningful case studies together and share business stories to help companies grow and scale through their IA/IP. Within this compendium, businesses will find actionable resources and insights to guide them on their IA/IP journey.

Mrs Rena Lee,
Chief Executive, IPOS

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This compendium affirms the growing recognition of IA/IP as key strategic assets for businesses. However, the lack of expertise in IP valuation and complexities associated with IP protection are key challenges businesses faced in managing their IP assets. We hope insights from this compendium will enable businesses to take proactive steps to enhance their IP awareness and include IP as part of their comprehensive business strategy.

Mr Kok Ping Soon,
Chief Executive Officer, SBF

Using IA/IP as Strategic Assets

In today's knowledge-driven economy, IA and IP are no longer just supplementary to business success, they are essential. In 2022, over 90% of the S&P 500's market value comprised IA, a staggering leap from just 17% in 1975. This dramatic shift underscores how IP, technology, and sustainability now define competitive advantage, far outpacing traditional sectors reliant on physical assets.

Recognising this paradigm, IPOS and SBF sought insights from a diverse group of Singapore businesses across industries and at various growth stages. Drawing from SBF's networks, including the Young Business Leaders Network (YBLN), the Singapore Women Entrepreneurs Network (SG-WEN) and the Digitalisation Committee (DC)¹, the case studies in this compendium offer actionable strategies for managing, protecting, and commercialising IP.

TAKE THE NEXT STEP!

Start by exploring the **IP Checklist** on page 9 to chart your IP journey. For more resources, click to visit IPOS' website.



Business Perspectives



VersaFleet, a logistic automation company, reported that

99% of its revenue

is derived from its IP portfolio.



Pan-United, a frontrunner in low-carbon concrete technologies, believes

strategic IA/IP is absolutely critical

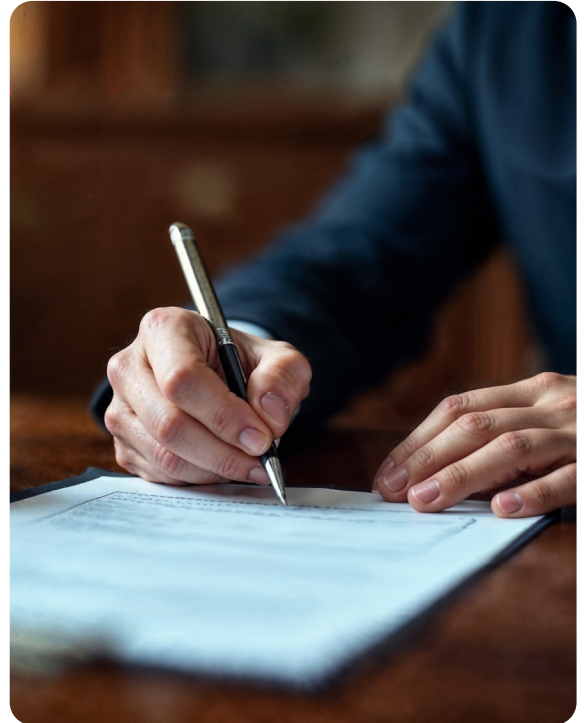
to sustain business success.

¹ SBF's networks bring together a diverse range of business leaders and innovators. The YBLN comprises young business professionals among the next generation of business leaders in Singapore. The SG-WEN is a group of leading female entrepreneurs who adopt diverse and innovative approaches to business. The DC consists of a group of businesses keen to advance digitalisation among the business community in Singapore.

Protecting and Managing IP

Effective IP management is becoming a priority for more business leaders, who are implementing practices and policies to safeguard these assets. Measures often include confidentiality and IP ownership clauses in employment contracts, along with non-disclosure agreements (NDAs) to protect sensitive information when working with external parties. While some businesses engage external IP law firms to manage their portfolios, provide technical expertise, and handle filings across multiple jurisdictions, others opt for an in-house approach. In some cases, founders or directors personally oversee their IP, using tools like the IPOS Go app to file trade marks directly.

In VersaFleet, IP management is not centralised but is distributed across various business functions, including Product Design, Engineering, and supporting functions such as Human Resources, Finance, and Corporate Function. This approach reflects the diverse considerations and nature of IP within the organisation.



PROTECT YOUR IP ON THE GO

The IPOS Go Mobile app keeps you updated on IP filings and offers essential services, including filing new trade mark applications, managing renewals, and conducting searches – all at your fingertips.



Business Perspectives



Life3 Biotech, an agri-food tech company actively files patents to protect its innovations and enhance its market standing. Patent filings are not only a measure of success but also a

critical tool in maintaining a competitive edge.



Lintec & Linnhoff, a global manufacturer and distributor, employs defensive IP strategies and secures trade marks across multiple jurisdictions to protect its existing market position and

prevent competitors from capitalising on its IP.

Leveraging IP in Partnerships

Technology transfer plays a pivotal role as forward-thinking businesses collaborate with research institutions and institutes of higher learning. By leveraging each other's IA/IP, these partnerships **co-create cutting-edge products**, transforming innovative ideas into tangible outcomes that benefit all parties involved.

Business Perspectives



Life3 Biotech partnered with NUS Engineering to integrate electrospinning technology into food tech, replicating the realistic texture of real meat.



CustodioTech, a cyber product and research company collaborated with Singapore Institute of Technology on cybersecurity related projects.



Glee Trees, a software provider, has collaborated on Joint AI Advisory Projects, where students use Gleematic—an AI tool—to develop innovative solutions for real-world challenges in the tourism sector.

Joint marketing and branding have emerged as powerful growth strategies. Business leaders we spoke to emphasised that they are working closely with their local channel partners to gain access to new markets.

Business Perspectives



JOS Furniture, a leading office furniture and furnishings provider, has joined forces with Sunon Furniture to leverage their combined brand equity and regional strengths.

By sharing market expertise, both companies can enhance their presence in previously untapped regions, expand brand visibility, and create new opportunities for growth and client engagement.

Licensing agreements play a key role in these collaborations, granting partners the right to use a company's brand or technology in exchange for royalties. This strategy not only monetises IP but also expands market reach efficiently.

The Key to Success: Strong Licensing Agreements

Well-structured licensing agreements are crucial to safeguarding the interests of all parties involved. They serve as a strong foundation for successful long-term partnerships.

Types of Licensing

Out-license

In-license

Cross-license

Business Perspectives

creativeateries

F&B brand **Creative Eateries** licenses their IP out to other businesses, by granting them the rights to use its brand and business model, in exchange for fees or royalties.

This allows Creative Eateries to **expand its market presence and generate additional revenue**.



Companies such as **Theo10** (skin and healthcare) and **Singapore Safety Glass** (glass fabricating) purchase technology licenses from institutions like Temasek Lifesciences Laboratory and A*STAR.

In this way, they **get access to cutting-edge innovations to maintain their competitive advantage**, and at the same time **avoid high research and development (R&D) costs**, which allows them to focus on commercialisation and other priorities.



Technology solutions provider, **Power Instrument** engages in cross-licensing agreements with partners to exchange IP and allow both parties to use each other's innovations.

This **enhances their ability to innovate while reducing legal and R&D expenses**, which can be allocated to other business needs.

RESOURCE SPOTLIGHT: IP BUSINESS GUIDES

Access IPOS International's business guides that offer practical tips, tools, and advice to overcome business challenges and leverage your IA/IP effectively.



Going Global with IP

As businesses increasingly expand to international markets through e-commerce and retail platforms, IP becomes a critical tool for success. The ASEAN region, with its dynamic growth and opportunities, is a prime target for such expansions. Protecting IP is key to safeguarding innovations and staying competitive in new markets.

Business Perspectives



For software company Sambaash, IP ownership not only enhances investor confidence and creates value, but also **acts as a blue ocean strategy** for entering new markets.



Fire Armour, a fire extinguisher supplier, aims to **leverage Singapore's strong reputation** by labeling its products as "assembled in Singapore" to enhance its appeal abroad.



Creative Eateries **registered its trade marks in multiple jurisdictions** to protect their portfolio of brands and ensure smoother entry into international markets.

GETTING STARTED



Fast-Track Your IP in ASEAN

In the ASEAN region, businesses can accelerate patent rights through programmes like the **ASEAN Patent Examination Co-operation (ASPEC)** and IPOS' partnerships with Cambodia, Laos, and Viet Nam.



Support for SMEs

For SMEs, the **Enterprise Singapore's Market Readiness Assistance (MRA)** programme offers financial support for costs like IP search and registration fees, making international expansion more accessible.



A Smarter Start with IP Grow

Companies seeking IP advice for expansion can use **GoBusiness IP Grow**, a free, one-stop platform that helps enterprises identify their IA/IP needs.

Conclusion

The world of IA/IP is rapidly transforming, driven by innovative partnerships, strategic management, and global expansion ambitions. Businesses are increasingly collaborating with research institutions and leveraging joint marketing efforts to gain a competitive edge. Licensing agreements, when well-structured, not only expand market reach and drive innovation, but also protect the interests of all parties.

Effective IA/IP management is no longer optional – it is a cornerstone of maintaining a competitive position. Whether handled internally or through external expertise, businesses are adopting diverse approaches, from proactive patent filings to defensive trade marks registrations, tailored to their unique models and priorities.



Global expansion, particularly in regions like ASEAN, underscores the critical role of IA/IP in facilitating market entry and building investor confidence. By leveraging regional acceleration programmes and support resources, businesses can reduce costs and streamline the process of IP registration and protection abroad.

Integrating IP into business strategies is a powerful driver of growth and innovation. Companies that embrace collaboration, effective management, and global expansion are better equipped to navigate the evolving IP landscape and achieve sustained success in a competitive global market.

Ready to Begin?

Start your IP journey with the checklist on page 9. This practical tool will guide you in evaluating and strengthening your company's systems for managing IA/IP, ensuring you are positioned to capitalise on opportunities in today's dynamic market.

IP Readiness Checklist

Kickstart your IP journey with this IP Readiness Checklist, adapted from the International Organisation for Standardisation (ISO) guidelines. Use it to evaluate the systems and processes your company has in place for managing IA/IP.

IA/IP are not just assets. They are the future of business. Are you ready to capitalise on them?

Internal - Do you have:

- ☐ an IP registered and know what are your organisation's key IA/IP?
- ☐ training (internal or external) provided to help staff acquire relevant IP skills?
- ☐ IP clauses incorporated in employment contracts?
- ☐ systems and processes to restrict access to key IP assets, for e.g., confidential information?
- ☐ a system or process to assess the value and protection of new ideas?

External- Do you have:

- ☐ access to external service providers for IP management services and advice?
- ☐ the practice of signing Non-Disclosure Agreements (NDAs) with third parties (e.g. investors, vendors, and partners) prior to sharing?
- ☐ IP ownership clauses in partnership agreements (for e.g., who owns the background/foreground IP)?
- ☐ in place ways to identify and assess potential licensing opportunities?
- ☐ processes to check whether new solutions may infringe third parties' IP rights?



Access the form here to receive the full IP Readiness checklist.

Acknowledgement

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creativeateries



GLEEMATIC

JAS & Sunon



sambaash
EdTech Enablers





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